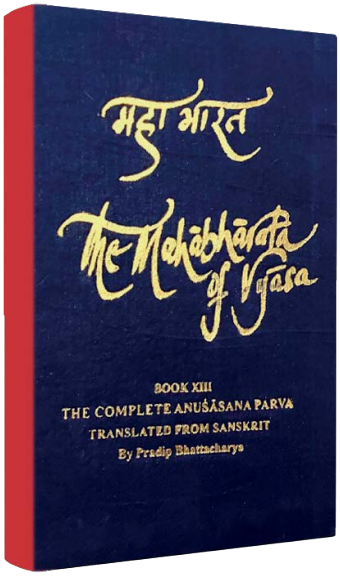
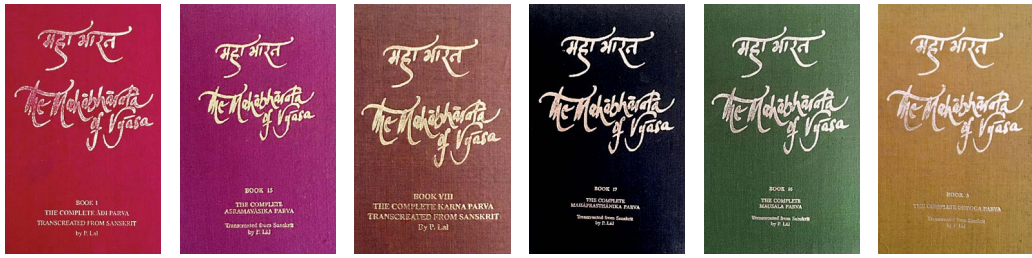




BOOKS

The Art of Translation

Prof P. Lal's ambitious English verse translation of the Mahabharata is now complete, with the last volume published by Writers Workshop



Indian readers and writers know the late Purushottam Lal (1929-2010) as a poet and professor who founded the Kolkata-based literary publishing house Writers Workshop in 1958. Creating a publishing house from scratch is tough in India. However, another one of Prof. Lal's projects proved to be even more gargantuan. In 1968, he started translating the entirety of the Mahabharata in English verse. Unfortunately, he passed away in 2010 before the project could be completed. His student Pradip Bhattacharya finished the incomplete 'parvas' of the Mahabharata—and now, all 18 volumes have been completed, the last to be published being the *Anusasana Parva*. Published by Writers Workshop, it is the only English translation in existence that follows each and every Sanskrit shloka and every single variation, including verses that prose translators have missed.

"My father first started working on the Mahabharata in the late '60s, with the Bhagavad Gita," says Ananda Lal, theatre critic, (retired) Jadavpur University professor and Prof. P. Lal's son. "Back then, he

BOOKS

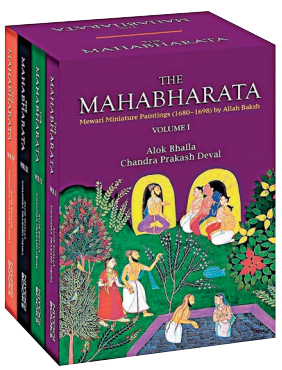
WORTH A THOUSAND WORDS

The 17th-century miniatures by Allah Baksh in the ***Mewari Mahabharata*** bring the great epic to life

In the world of classical Indian painting, it's not often that we see scenes from the Mahabharata, apart from the iconic image of the Bhagavad Gita dialogue and the disrobing of Draupadi. And here we have before us a gorgeous set of books from Niyogi that allow our eyes to see the entire Mahabharata in pictures. I will confess to feeling like Sanjaya as, like him, I can see everything at once, even the so-called 'side stories'.

The last decade of art-historical work has brought Rajput paintings to our attention, particularly the renderings of the Indian epics from Mewar. These Mahabharata paintings are from the late 17th century and appear to come right after the *Mewar Ramayana*. These were commissioned by Maharana Jai Singh and produced by one Allah Baksh. The pictures are accompanied by a short and often fragmentary text in Mewari, which the editors of these splendid volumes have translated into Hindi (Deval) and into English (Bhalla).

The books are beautifully produced and the images, which appear to be in excellent condition, delight the eye. In reproduction, the colours are bright and fresh, the paintings pulse with action but remain delicate in their depiction of transparent garments and other royal accoutrements. The natural world is everywhere—trees, bushes, ponds, skies, clouds, flowers—the animals are robust and fierce. Many frames contain multiple episodes from a narrative, and so we have, for example, a single painting that shows us how the gentle wish-fulfilling Nandini, a sturdy black



THE MAHABHARATA
Mewari Miniature Paintings (1680–1698) by Allah Baksh
By Alok Bhalla and Chandra Prakash Deval
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹7,600; 1,994 pages
(four volumes)